

Introduction

This essay will discuss four key educational topics linked to autism and contemporary practices. These topics are accessibility in education, allied health in school, inclusive classrooms and best practice for educators and schools. The impact of educational experiences on individuals will be considered within the topics. Key issues will be discussed that children with autism are faced with such as anxiety, difficulties in social interaction, behaviour and sensory issues. The development of learning support knowledge will be discussed in terms of teachers' awareness of autism and its symptoms and the strategies available. It will look at accessibility of schools and an education using different methods. It will discuss the importance of Allied Health in schools in supporting teachers to assist children. Also, looking at the curriculum and ensuring a child's needs are met using inclusive education strategies. It will also be considered how educators and schools can be supported to aid children within contemporary practices in the classroom. The definition of autism has also changed over several decades which has affected whether children receive support and whether their autism is diagnosed (Silberman, 2001; Voices from Spectrum, 2017; Rydzewska, 2012; Bonnello, 2015). Support knowledge needs to continue to be developed as more diagnosis continue to be made.

1 Accessibility in education

Modes of learning

There are many strategies and best practice support that teachers can apply to ensure children with autism have accessibility to education. There are many modes of learning, not only face to face teaching but online, flexi teaching, distance learning these different ways ensure that all children can access a school. There have been difficulties with some parents accessing their chosen school for their child (The Strait Times, 2017).

Curriculum

It is important that the curriculum within a school is adapted and modified to ensure that it is accessible, relevant and appropriate for the individuals it reaches. The curriculum should be delivered in an alternative method and alter the style of teaching to ensure individuals achieves success (Arnaiz, 2016). Extra- curricular activities are thus important, and these should be made available in schools to all individuals and to move away from following a strict, rigid curriculum (McMurray, 2016; Arnaiz, 2016).

Flexible

The issues highlight the need for schools to be flexible (Edutopia ,2015; 2017) and personalise the learning to ensure that the needs of children with autism are met and benefits and appeals to them. Educators need to ensure that the education system is restructured to ensure that individuals face less challenges to ensure that education stays relevant, inclusive and supportive (Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2013; Girton Grammar School, 2016; Nellie May, 2015)

Physical space

It is important for schools to have flexible and adaptable classrooms including physical space and seating positions to suit the needs of children. This is based upon the content they are accessing and whether they need to sit independently or in groups to ensure effective, engaging, learning (Edutopia, 2017; Edutopia, 2015).

Personalised learning

Personalised learning is another contemporary practice which is vital within a classroom to ensure that a child's needs are met (Edutopia, 2017; Totsmart Education, 2016; Nellie May 2015; Hawker Brownlow Education, 2015). It ensures that the work set by the teachers appeals to the child and is engaging and pitched at the correct level and therefore is subjective to that specific child.

Differentiation - Adapting learning

Children with autism will ask to be excluded from activities such as physical education if these are too difficult (Healy, 2013). It is important that differentiation occurs within a classroom to ensure that the work is pitched at the appropriate level for the child and not too difficult (Hawker Brownlow Education, 2013). This reasserts the view that teachers need more training in autism (Healy 2013, McMurray, 2016, Sanahuja, 2016, Lakkala, 2016). Children need to be actively involved in their learning and more practical methods used (Arnaiz, 2016; Donahoo, 2013).

Strengths of the child

Educators need to ensure that children are engaged in their learning by merging their strengths and interests into their learning (DIY, 2016; Edutopia, 2017; Donahoo, 2013; VOA, 2016; Bonnelo, 2015; Post 21 Club, 2013; Forbes 2017; Silberman, 2001). This will boost their social skills and self-esteem. This can work as many have a hyper interest that they can excel in (Silberman, 2001).

2 Allied health in school

Individuals with autism have three main difficulties which are with communication, social interaction and behaviour (Fast Company, 2017; Silberman, 2001; Autism Queensland, 2016; De Luca, 2012). These individuals are affected in many areas such as having sensory issues, bullying in school, anxiety, stigma, late diagnosis, lack of knowledge of autism of the educators around them and barriers in inclusive education. Educators within the school environment need the support of Allied Health professionals such as Speech Therapist and Occupational Therapist to be able to help with children with autism. Allied Health professionals can suggest advice and strategies for teachers to implement for the children within their classrooms (Howcast, 2014; Tomcheck, 2017).

Available Therapies

There are many types of contemporary therapy that are available today for individuals with autism to access. Educators need to introduce therapies into the classroom and try new methods such as animals, game and play therapy (Howscast, 2004, O’Haire, 2013, New Scientist, 2016; Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2016; Tomcheck, 2017; Nall 2018). Cognitive behaviour therapy could be used which involves discussing feelings, reactions and relaxation strategies. This can also aid a child in making friends (Raising Children Network, 2017).

Behavioural issues

Behaviour challenges can occur in individuals with autism and these can often arise such as if a routine or schedule is altered (Silberman, 2001; Cheak-Zamora, 2015). Allied Health professionals can suggest therapies. Behaviour therapy is recommended to combat poor behaviour (Carpenter, 2015; Nall, 2018). The speech and occupational therapist can introduce play- based therapy into a classroom (Nall, 2018).

Sensory issues

Another issue for individuals with autism is their sensory issues (Healy, 2013; De Luca, 2012; Legge, 2016; Reallookautism, 2011). A child could be given headphones to reduce the surrounding noise which could help with example with anxiety (Ikuta, 2016, Hannah, 2012). It is important therefore that their sensory needs are met via for example a sensory room that two schools introduced in Australia (Edutopia, 2017; Davis and Dennis Films, 2015). OTs recommend the use of sensory items and can supply resources to support the children. A child can have a safe place such as a quiet room that they can visit in the school to calm them down (Raising Children, 2017) that can be set up by Allied Health professionals.

Late diagnosis

Allied Health can play a part in noticing traits of autism in a child in school. It is important that a diagnosis of autism is made early on in an individual’s life (Legge, 2016;

Russel, Golding, Norwich, Emond, and Steer, 2012; Rydzewska, 2012; Sarris, 2015). This will enable a child to have the necessary support needs and interventions to be put into place immediately at school and at home.

Mental health conditions

Many children with autism experience anxiety and have a negative self -evaluation of themselves (Hannah, 2012). Individuals need to be given advice by teachers with suggested options such as being advised to see a General Practitioner or counsellor or given anti-anxiety medication or access to behavioural programs (Australian Family Physician, 2015; The National Autistic Society, 2016; Carpenter, 2015; Autism Speaks, 2017). Children can be advised to peruse websites for advice and support on mental health issue (Bonnello, 2015; The National Autistic Society, 2016). If schools can ensure that mental health is well and stable in the children that attend, then this can be perceived as accessing education by referring parents to medical professionals for their children.

3 Inclusive classrooms

Inclusion is a key educational topic. Children with autism need extra classroom supports to ensure that they can reach the set learning with no barriers and this is then classed as an inclusive classroom. This education pedagogy is integrated to ensure that individuals with special educational needs feel cherished, included and wanted (Monsen, 2014; Arnaiz, 2016; McMurray, 2016; Edutopia, 2017; Lakkala, 2016; Raising Children Network, 2017).

It must be considered that educational experiences are important to all children via the inclusive education concept.

Key issues

Social interaction and communication

Children with autism often face limitations in the area of communication and social interactions such as making friends (Amaze, 2017; Australian Family Physician, 2015; Erinclen, 2013;

Gray, 2014; Hannah, 2012; Healy, 2013; Nall, 2015; Raising Children, (n.d); The Atlantic, 2014). Children need to be included socially and it is the responsibility of schools to ensure children are supported in this area. Girton Grammar School (2016) were able to introduce a sports program that allowed children with autism to make friends with children from different schools. This therefore is placing less onus on the skill of the sport and changes the focus to benefit children with this deficit. There are also therapies available to help with social communication (Howcast, 2014).

Support needs

Speech

Many individuals have issues with speech thus AAC devices aid individuals in this area (Ronski, 2015). Teachers need to ensure that they adapt their lesson plans to cater for children with autism in their classrooms to ensure inclusive classrooms, they need to use Prologue or other forms.

Sensory

They need to use sensory objects to regulate the children in their classrooms to ensure that they are then ready to learn.

Development of support knowledge

It has been a long running key issue regarding ensuring children have access to an inclusive classroom and that they are not hindered or denied access from learning as their peers.

Barriers

The barrier to inclusion is that many schools feel that they are not appropriately equipped to cater for individuals with autism (McMurray, 2016; Sanahuja, 2016; The Strait Times, 2017, Arnaiz, 2016). This could be due to lack of knowledge or training, or lack of resources and funding.

Impact

A child could feel bullied such because they are unable to carry out an activity confidently as not enough educational support needs are provided to ensure that they can access the learning to ensure an inclusive approach (Healy, 2013).

First Person Perspective needs- Key issue

In (Healy, 2013) it discusses how children with autism found some activities very difficult in physical education therefore it is important to hear their voice through a person first perspective. Adaptation needs to be carried out to ensure that they have an inclusive school and classroom. Teachers need to use information directly from these children to try and decide what is best support practise for these individuals (Healy, 2013). In Girton Grammar School (2016) the children in this programme were asked how they felt about it and they confirmed they enjoyed it and were making friends which illustrates a success.

There are many strategies that teachers can adopt in their classrooms. Peer training can be used when children who are developing typically, integrate with those with autism (Raising Children, 2017). A child with autism could play with a neuro-typical child therefore as they model playing. A child could be taught self- management techniques to allow them to learn how to maintain their behaviour (Raising Children, 2017).

4 Best practice support for educators and schools

There are many new developments in the learning support knowledge of educators. Many teachers do not have adequate training in autism to be able to identify symptoms of autism and support the children in their classrooms (Healy, 2013, McMurray, 2016, Sanahuja, 2016, Lakkala, 2016; Monsen, 2014). They therefore lack the awareness of the best support strategize to use to help children displaying traits of autism (Healy, 2013, McMurray, 2016, Sanahuja, 2016, Lakkala, 2016). They need to adapt and change and be flexible within the curriculum and life within the classroom. Altering modes such as homework to be given in a different form of homework allowing a child to film, dictate, type or draw their ideas rather than

writing them. Educators such as teachers need training to ensure that they are confident to support children with autism in their classrooms. This is slowly being developed through more training on how to support and including special needs knowledge on teacher training courses (National Autism Society, 2018).

Education programs in schools

Schools need to ensure that interventions are recommended for individuals with autism (Ronski,2015, Guldberg, 2010; Kasari, 2016; Zenko, 2014; Carpenter, 2015). School plays a vital role in ensuring that individuals become equipped as they leave school organized for adulthood (Wilczynski, 2013). It is essential that education programs are introduced for individuals with disabilities (Wilczynski, 2013; PBSO, 2016; Rulerapproach, 2011; Trojan Live 2017). Schools need to teach children strategies to cope such as mentioned in the (Ruler Approach,2011; Real look Autism, 2011).

Individual Education Plans

Schools need to ensure that their educators support the needs of the children by implementing an individual personalised education plans (Rydzewska, 2012 ; Gray, 2014 ; Ambitious about autism, 2012; Zenko, 2014, Ronski, 2015; Guldberg, 2010; Sarris, 2015 ; Kasari, 2016; Trembath, 2015). These plans allow educators to consider a child's specific needs and regularly set targets and goals.

Stigma, mental health

Schools need to reduce stigma and promote awareness of autism in the school and surrounding community. Many individuals do not wish to acknowledge a deterioration in mental health due to the stigma and fail to seek support (Neinstein Lawyers, 2012; ABC TV, 2013; Insight SBS, 2017; Mission Australia, 2017; Wax, 2012; Lees, 2017; Parnell, 2017; Rosenberg, 2017; Mental Health Commission Canada, 2013; Dow, 2018; Bradford, 2015;

Stanford, 2017). To combat stigma for children with autism we must make society more aware of autism.

Carers

Parents and carers play an important support role in the lives of individuals with autism (Autism Spectrum Australia, 2012; Raising Children Network, 2017; Voices from Spectrum, 2012). Parents are a child's best resource and they should be involved collaboratively in their children's education (Billington, 2000; McMurray, 2016; Legge, 2016; Raising Children Network, 2017). There are many barriers such as access to the right school can be a problem for parents (Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2014, The Strait Times, 2017). Carers need support from services to help them to cope within themselves through counselling, carer support groups and from GP referrals (Ronski, 2015; Raising Children Network, 2017).

Conclusion

In conclusion, the impact of the changes in educational pedagogy is important as schools are changing their curriculum. They are placing more importance on including children via the inclusive pedagogy. Children will enjoy and be more engaged and it allows schools to be places that all children can enjoy and have a fair and equal education regardless of their disability. As schools continue to trial strategies, such as sensory rooms to determine what is successful then methods are becoming increasingly effective. Schools are slowly becoming more confident in ensuring that they are equipped to provide and ensure every single child excels in their school using learning support needs. Educators are using more technology and to ensure that education practice is hence current and up to date to fit with today's children (DIY, 2016; Wired 2011; Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2013; Ronski, 2015). There are now faster diagnosis' and thus an increase in autism being identified (Autism Spectrum Australia, 2012; Silberman, 2001). Ultimately, individuals require support to ensure that they remain independent by helping them with their strengths (VOA, 2016; Bonnello, 2015; Post 21 Club,

2013). Collectively the issues of accessibility in education, allied health in schools, inclusive classrooms and best practice support for education and schools all work collectively for the same goal of ensuring a child with autism is supported in education.

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